

# Email Infrastructure & Deliverability Playbook — FirstKnock.online

## Email Infrastructure & Deliverability Playbook

FirstKnock.online — Enterprise-Grade Cold Outreach Strategy for D2D & Field Sales Teams  
2025

*This playbook is the definitive operational guide for FirstKnock.online's email outreach infrastructure. It covers every layer of the stack — from Gmail warm-up protocols to enterprise-grade domain rotation — designed specifically for a SaaS startup targeting door-to-door and field sales teams.*

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## 1. Executive Summary

### Strategic Overview

FirstKnock.online is building a cold outreach engine to reach D2D and field sales teams at scale.

The challenge is universal for early-stage SaaS: you need to generate pipeline fast, but aggressive sending without proper infrastructure will permanently damage your sender reputation — killing deliverability before your first deal closes. This playbook solves that problem with a disciplined, two-phase approach.

Phase 1 establishes a safe, monitored sending foundation using the existing firstknockhelp@gmail.com account. Phase 2 migrates to a professional custom-domain infrastructure capable of scaling to 500+ emails per day across multiple lookalike domains and dedicated mailboxes. Every decision in this playbook is optimized for one outcome: landing in the inbox, not the spam folder.

|                                                           |                                                                 |                                                                    |                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>50/dayGmail Safe Cap</b><br>Phase 1 Max Send<br>Volume | <b>500+/dayCustom<br/>Domain Scale</b> Phase 2<br>Target Volume | <b>&lt;0.1%Industry Best<br/>Practice</b> Spam<br>Complaint Target | <b>4–6 wksPer<br/>Domain/Account</b><br>Warm-Up Period |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|

## Why a Phased Approach Matters

Sender reputation is not a setting — it is earned over time through consistent, low-volume, high-engagement sending. Internet Service Providers (ISPs) like Google and Microsoft evaluate every sending domain and IP address against a rolling history of behavior. A brand-new account or domain that immediately sends hundreds of emails per day triggers algorithmic spam filters, resulting in bulk folder placement or outright rejection.

The phased approach protects FirstKnock.online on two fronts: it builds a positive sending history during Phase 1 while simultaneously preparing the technical infrastructure for Phase 2 scaling. This means that by the time FirstKnock is ready to send 500 emails per day, the domains and mailboxes doing the sending already have weeks of positive reputation behind them.

## Key Goals

- Achieve consistent inbox placement above 90% across all outreach campaigns
- Maintain spam complaint rates strictly below 0.1% at all times
- Build a scalable domain and mailbox infrastructure that supports 500+ daily sends without reputation risk
- Establish SPF, DKIM, and DMARC authentication on all sending domains before the first cold email is sent
- Create a repeatable warm-up and monitoring protocol that the FirstKnock team can execute without external consultants

Core Principle: Never push a single Google Workspace account or Gmail account to its technical limit for cold outreach. Horizontal scaling across multiple inboxes and domains — not vertical volume increases on a single account — is the only safe path to 500+ emails per day.

## 2.1 Gmail Daily Sending Limits

Gmail operates on two distinct sets of limits that are frequently confused: the technical system limit and the cold outreach safe limit. Understanding the difference is critical — violating the cold outreach safe limit will not trigger an immediate error message, but it will silently destroy your sender reputation over days and weeks.

**Table 1 — Gmail Sending Limits: Technical vs. Cold Outreach Safe Thresholds**

| Limit Type                 | Daily Volume       | Risk Level              | Notes                                                                  |
|----------------------------|--------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Technical System Limit     | 2,000 emails/day   | N/A — Technical ceiling | Google Workspace hard cap; never approach this for cold outreach       |
| Bulk Sender Classification | 5,000+ emails/day  | Extreme                 | Triggers strict Gmail compliance rules and mandatory unsubscribe links |
| Danger Zone                | 300+ emails/day    | Critical                | Severe risk of permanent sender reputation damage                      |
| Cold Outreach Safe Limit   | 100–150 emails/day | Low                     | Recommended maximum for established, warmed-up accounts                |
| Conservative Cold Limit    | 20–40 emails/day   | Very Low                | Best practice for newer accounts or lower-reputation domains           |
| FirstKnock Phase 1 Cap     | 50 emails/day      | Very Low                | Strict maximum for firstknockhelp@gmail.com during Phase 1             |

FirstKnock Phase 1 Rule: Cap all sending from firstknockhelp@gmail.com at 50 emails per day, regardless of campaign urgency. Exceeding this threshold during the warm-up period risks permanent blacklisting of the account — a setback that cannot be reversed.

## 2.2 Week-by-Week Warm-Up Schedule

The firstknockhelp@gmail.com account requires a structured warm-up period of 6–8 weeks before

reaching the 50 emails/day Phase 1 cap. During the first week, zero cold emails should be sent. The account should only engage in genuine two-way email conversations to establish a positive sending history with Google's algorithms.

**Table 2 — FirstKnock Phase 1 Gmail Warm-Up Schedule (Weeks 1–8)**

| Week   | Daily Send Volume       | Cumulative Sent (Est.) | Cold Outreach Allowed | Key Actions                                                                                                   |
|--------|-------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Week 1 | 3–5 warm-up emails only | 21–35                  | None                  | Send only to known contacts. Reply to emails. Build positive engagement signals. No cold outreach whatsoever. |
| Week 2 | 8–12 warm-up emails     | 77–119                 | None                  | Continue warm-up with real conversations. Subscribe to newsletters and engage. Monitor for any flags.         |
| Week 3 | 15–20 emails/day        | 182–259                | 5–10 cold emails/day  | Introduce first cold outreach at very low volume. Prioritize highly targeted, personalized messages only.     |
| Week 4 | 25–30 emails/day        | 357–469                | 15–20 cold emails/day | Ramp up cold outreach. Monitor bounce rate and spam complaints daily. Pause if bounce rate exceeds 1%.        |
| Week 5 | 35–40 emails/day        | 602–749                | 25–30 cold emails/day | Continue scaling. A/B test subject lines. Verify list hygiene before each send batch.                         |

|          |                     |             |                       |                                                                                      |
|----------|---------------------|-------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Week 6   | 45–50 emails/day    | 917–1,099   | 35–40 cold emails/day | Approach Phase 1 cap. Full monitoring protocol active. Begin planning Phase 2 domain |
| Week 7–8 | 50 emails/day (cap) | 1,267–1,449 | 45–50 cold emails/day | Maintain cap. Optimize sequences. Begin Phase 2 DNS configuration in parallel.       |

Warm-Up Trigger: If at any point during the warm-up your bounce rate exceeds 2% or you receive a single spam complaint, immediately pause sending for 48 hours, clean your list, and resume at the previous week's volume — not the current week's target.

### 2.3 Monitoring Bounce Rates, Spam Complaints & Engagement

Gmail does not provide a native analytics dashboard for cold outreach metrics. You will need to rely on your sending tool (see Section 2.6) and Google Postmaster Tools to monitor sender health. Set up Google Postmaster Tools immediately — it is free and provides domain-level reputation data, spam rate trends, and delivery error reports.

**Table 3 — Email Health Monitoring Thresholds for Phase 1**

| Metric               | Green (Safe) | Yellow (Warning) | Red (Pause Immediately) | Monitoring Frequency           |
|----------------------|--------------|------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Bounce Rate          | < 1%         | 1%–1.9%          | geq 2%                  | Daily during active campaigns  |
| Spam Complaint Rate  | < 0.1%       | 0.1%–0.29%       | geq 0.3%                | Daily — check Postmaster Tools |
| Open Rate            | > 30%        | 20%–30%          | < 20%                   | Per campaign send              |
| Reply Rate           | > 5%         | 2%–5%            | < 2%                    | Per campaign send              |
| Unsubscribe Rate     | < 0.5%       | 0.5%–1%          | geq 1%                  | Per campaign send              |
| Inbox Placement Rate | > 90%        | 80%–90%          | < 80%                   | Weekly via seed testing        |

- Google Postmaster Tools: Register firstknockhelp@gmail.com domain at postmaster.google.com for free spam rate and reputation monitoring
- Sending Tool Dashboard: Use your chosen cold email tool (see Section 2.6) to track open rates, reply rates, and bounce rates per campaign
- Manual Spot Checks: Send test emails to seed accounts (personal Gmail, Outlook, Yahoo) weekly to verify inbox placement
- Blacklist Monitoring: Check MXToolbox.com weekly to confirm your sending domain is not listed on any major blacklists

## 2.4 SPF and DKIM Configuration for Gmail

Even when sending from a Gmail account, proper authentication is mandatory. SPF and DKIM tell receiving mail servers that your emails are legitimate and authorized — without them, even well-crafted emails will be flagged as suspicious. For Phase 1 using firstknockhelp@gmail.com, Google handles most of this automatically, but if you upgrade to Google Workspace (strongly recommended even in Phase 1), you must configure these records manually.

### SPF Record Setup

SPF (Sender Policy Framework) is a DNS TXT record that specifies which mail servers are authorized to send email on behalf of your domain. For a Google Workspace account on a custom domain, add the following TXT record to your domain's DNS:

**Table 4 — SPF Record for Google Workspace**

| Record Type | Host/Name       | Value                                     | TTL  |
|-------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------|------|
| TXT         | @ (root domain) | v=spf1<br>include:_spf.google.com<br>~all | 3600 |

- Log in to your domain registrar (Namecheap, GoDaddy, or Google Domains)
- Navigate to DNS Management rightarrow Add New Record
- Set Type: TXT, Host: @, Value: v=spf1 include:\_spf.google.com ~all
- Save and allow up to 48 hours for DNS propagation
- Verify using MXToolbox SPF Lookup tool at mxtoolbox.com/spf.aspx
- Important: Keep DNS lookups at or below 10 total — each 'include:' statement counts as one lookup

### DKIM Signing via Google Workspace

DKIM (DomainKeys Identified Mail) adds a cryptographic signature to every outgoing email, allowing receiving servers to verify that the message was not tampered with in transit. Use 2048-bit keys for maximum security and deliverability.

1. Log in to Google Workspace Admin Console at [admin.google.com](https://admin.google.com)
2. Navigate to Apps rightarrow Google Workspace rightarrow Gmail rightarrow Authenticate Email
3. Select your domain and click 'Generate New Record'
4. Set DKIM key length to 2048-bit (required for modern deliverability standards)
5. Copy the generated TXT record value (it will look like: v=DKIM1; k=rsa; p=MIIBIjANBgkq...)
6. Add a new TXT record in your DNS: Host: google.\_domainkey, Value: [paste the generated key]
7. Return to Google Admin Console and click 'Start Authentication'
8. Verify DKIM is active using MXToolbox DKIM Lookup — allow 24–48 hours for propagation

## DMARC Policy Setup

DMARC (Domain-based Message Authentication, Reporting & Conformance) ties SPF and DKIM together and tells receiving servers what to do with emails that fail authentication. Always start with `p=none` to collect data before enforcing stricter policies.

**Table 5 — DMARC Policy Progression for FirstKnock.online**

| Stage                | DMARC Policy              | DNS TXT Record Value                                                            | When to Apply                                                          |
|----------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Stage 1 — Monitor    | <code>p=none</code>       | <code>v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmARC@firstknock.online</code>               | Immediately upon setup — collect reports for 2–4 weeks                 |
| Stage 2 — Quarantine | <code>p=quarantine</code> | <code>v=DMARC1; p=quarantine; pct=25; rua=mailto:dmARC@firstknock.online</code> | After confirming SPF/DKIM alignment — move 25% of failing mail to spam |
| Stage 3 — Reject     | <code>p=reject</code>     | <code>v=DMARC1; p=reject; rua=mailto:dmARC@firstknock.online</code>             | After 60+ days of clean reports — full enforcement                     |

## 2.5 Email Tracking Best Practices

Email tracking — specifically open tracking pixels and click tracking links — is one of the most common causes of spam filter triggers for cold outreach. The core problem is that most email platforms use shared tracking domains, and if any other sender on that shared domain has been flagged for spam, your emails inherit that negative reputation.

### Open Tracking vs. Click Tracking Tradeoffs

- Open Tracking: Uses a 1x1 invisible pixel embedded in the email. Modern email clients (especially Gmail and Apple Mail with Mail Privacy Protection) now pre-load images, making open rate data increasingly unreliable — often inflated by 20–40%

- Click Tracking: Rewrites all links in your email through a tracking redirect URL. This is the higher-risk tracking method for deliverability, as spam filters actively scan link destinations
- Plain Text Emails: Have no tracking pixels and no rewritten links — they are the safest format for cold outreach and typically achieve higher reply rates because they feel more human
- HTML Emails: Support full tracking but carry higher spam filter risk — reserve for warm audiences and newsletter-style communications

**Recommended Approach for FirstKnock Cold Outreach**

- Use plain-text or minimal-HTML emails for all cold outreach — no images, no logos, no fancy formatting
- Disable open tracking for Phase 1 cold outreach — the data is unreliable and the pixel increases spam risk
- If using click tracking, configure a custom tracking domain (CNAME record) in your DNS rather than using the platform's shared tracking domain
- Keep emails under 80 words for initial outreach — brevity signals confidence and avoids content-based spam triggers
- Never include more than one link in a cold email — multiple links dramatically increase spam filter scores
- Use reply rate as your primary engagement metric, not open rate — replies are the strongest positive signal you can send to ISPs

**2.6 Compatible Email Sending Tools Comparison**

The following tools are compatible with Gmail and Google Workspace for Phase 1 cold outreach. Each has distinct strengths depending on FirstKnock's current stage, budget, and technical capacity. The recommendation column reflects what is most appropriate for a D2D SaaS startup in early-stage outreach.

**Table 6 — Cold Email Sending Tools Comparison for FirstKnock.online (2025)**

| Tool | Key Features | Monthly Pricing | Gmail Compatibility | Warm-Up Feature | Setup Difficulty | Best For | FirstKnock Recommendation |
|------|--------------|-----------------|---------------------|-----------------|------------------|----------|---------------------------|
|------|--------------|-----------------|---------------------|-----------------|------------------|----------|---------------------------|



|              |                                                                                                               |                                           |                                                          |                                      |                                      |                                                           |                                                                                               |
|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Instantly.ai | AI sequence drafting, 94% inbox placement, P2P warm-up network, 450M+ lead database, unlimited email accounts | \$30–\$37/month (flat fee)                | Excellent — built for Gmail/Workspace                    | Yes — automated P2P warm-up included | Low — intuitive UI                   | Agencies and startups scaling fast with multiple accounts | Top Pick for Phase 1 & 2 — best value, unlimited accounts, strong warm-up                     |
| Smartlead    | Dynamic IP rotation, multi-inbox automation, native CRM integrations,                                         | \$32.50–\$39/month                        | Excellent — supports unlimited Gmail/Workspace mailboxes | Yes — built-in warm-up               | Medium — more configuration required | High-volume scaling operations                            | Strong Phase 2 choice — better for scaling than Phase 1 simplicity                            |
| Lemlist      | Multichannel outreach (LinkedIn + calls), custom images/videos, dynamic personalization                       | \$32–\$69/month (per seat)                | Good — 1–5 accounts per tier                             | Yes — warm-up included               | Medium                               | Creative personalization campaigns, human-touch outreach  | Good for personalization but expensive to scale; 86% inbox placement is lower than competitor |
| Woodpecker   | content Safe/compliant outreach, warm-up features, personalized email sequences, SMB-focused                  | Not publicly listed — contact for pricing | Good — Gmail compatible                                  | Yes — warm-up included               | Low — SMB-friendly interface         | SMBs prioritizing compliance and safety over volume       | Solid safe choice but pricing opacity is a concern for budget planning                        |

|          |                                                                                                       |                                        |                                   |                                 |                                    |                                                          |                                                                                                      |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reply.io | Multi-channel (email + LinkedIn + calls), strong CRM workflow integrations, sales engagement platform | Not publicly listed — per-seat pricing | Good — per-seat Gmail integration | Limited — not a primary feature | High — enterprise-level complexity | Full sales engagement platforms with CRM-heavy workflows | Overkill for Phase 1; per-seat pricing makes scaling expensive — revisit for Phase 2 CRM integration |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

FirstKnock Tool Recommendation: Start with Instantly.ai at \$30–\$37/month. It offers unlimited email accounts (critical for Phase 2 scaling), built-in P2P warm-up, and the highest reported inbox placement rate at 94%. The flat-fee pricing model means your cost does not increase as you add more sending accounts — a significant advantage over per-seat tools like Reply.io and Lemlist.

### 3. Phase 2 — Future Scaling Infrastructure (Migration Plan)

#### 3.1 Secondary Lookalike Domain Strategy

The single most important rule in cold email infrastructure is this: never use your primary company domain (firstknock.online) for cold outreach. Your primary domain is your brand. If it gets blacklisted — even temporarily — it affects your website, your product emails, your investor communications, and every other business-critical email you send. Secondary lookalike domains absorb all the risk of cold outreach while keeping your primary domain pristine.

#### Why Secondary Domains Are Non-Negotiable

- Domain reputation is permanent — a blacklisted domain cannot be fully rehabilitated; it must be retired
- Cold outreach inherently carries higher spam complaint risk than transactional email — isolate that risk on expendable domains
- Multiple domains enable horizontal scaling: 5 domains times 3 mailboxes times 40 emails/day = 600 emails/day safely
- Secondary domains can be retired and replaced if reputation degrades, without any impact on firstknock.online

#### Recommended Domain Naming Conventions for FirstKnock

Table 7 — Recommended Lookalike Domains for FirstKnock.online Phase 2

| Domain Example     | Use Case                                                     | TLD Strategy                  | Priority       |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|----------------|
| tryfirstknock.com  | Primary cold outreach domain — action-oriented, professional | Standard .com — highest trust | 1 — Buy First  |
| getfirstknock.com  | Secondary cold outreach domain — conversion-focused          | Standard .com — highest trust | 2 — Buy Second |
| firstknockapp.com  | Product-focused outreach — targets tech-savvy buyers         | .com — strong trust signal    | 3 — Buy Third  |
| firstknock-crm.com | Vertical-specific outreach for CRM/sales tool buyers         | Hyphenated .com — acceptable  | 4 — Buy Fourth |
| firstknockio.com   | Modern SaaS-style domain for tech-forward prospects          | .com variant of .io brand     | 5 — Buy Fifth  |

- Where to Buy: Namecheap (best pricing), Google Domains (seamless Workspace integration), GoDaddy (wide availability), Cloudflare Registrar (at-cost pricing, no markup)
- Domain Age: Newly registered domains have zero reputation — they must be warmed up before any cold sending. Purchase domains 4–6 weeks before you plan to use them
- TLD Selection: Prioritize .com domains — they carry the highest inherent trust with spam filters. Avoid .xyz, .info, .biz, and other low-trust TLDs
- Blacklist Check: Before purchasing any domain, run it through MXToolbox Blacklist Check to confirm it has no prior spam history
- Forwarding: Configure all secondary domains to forward to firstknock.online so prospects who investigate the sender see a legitimate, professional website
- Mailbox Limit: Never create more than 3 email accounts per domain — this is the safe maximum for reputation management

## Domain-to-Volume Planning

**Table 8 — Domain and Mailbox Requirements by Target Daily Volume**

| Target Daily Volume | Domains Required | Mailboxes Required | Emails per Mailbox/Day | Notes                                         |
|---------------------|------------------|--------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 50 emails/day       | 1 domain         | 2 mailboxes        | 25 emails/mailbox      | Phase 1 equivalent — single domain sufficient |

|                   |               |                 |                      |                                                |
|-------------------|---------------|-----------------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 150 emails/day    | 2 domains     | 4–5 mailboxes   | 30–40 emails/mailbox | Early Phase 2 — begin domain rotation          |
| 300 emails/day    | 3–4 domains   | 8–10 mailboxes  | 30–40 emails/mailbox | Mid Phase 2 — full rotation active             |
| 500 emails/day    | 5–6 domains   | 13–17 mailboxes | 30–40 emails/mailbox | Full Phase 2 scale — all domains active        |
| 1,000+ emails/day | 10–12 domains | 25–34 mailboxes | 30–40 emails/mailbox | Advanced scale — consider private SMTP servers |

### 3.2 Step-by-Step DNS Configuration

DNS configuration is the technical foundation of your email infrastructure. Every secondary domain must have all five record types configured before a single email is sent. Budget approximately 30 minutes per domain for initial setup, plus 24–48 hours for DNS propagation. The following examples use `tryfirstknock.com` as the reference domain.

#### Complete DNS Record Reference

**Table 9 — Complete DNS Configuration for `tryfirstknock.com` (Template for All Secondary Domains)**

| Record Type | Host/Name         | Value / Configuration                                     | Purpose                                       | TTL  |
|-------------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|------|
| TXT (SPF)   | @                 | v=spf1<br>include:_spf.google.com ~all                    | Authorizes Google to send on behalf of domain | 3600 |
| TXT (DKIM)  | google._domainkey | v=DKIM1; k=rsa; p=[2048-bit public key from Google Admin] | Cryptographic email signature verification    | 3600 |
| TXT (DMARC) | _dmarc            | v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@tryfirstknock.com      | Email authentication policy and reporting     | 3600 |

|                          |       |                                                          |                                                                        |      |
|--------------------------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| CNAME (Tracking)         | track | track.yoursendingplatform.com (e.g., track.instantly.ai) | Custom click/open tracking domain — avoids shared blacklisted trackers | 3600 |
| MX (Email Routing)       | @     | ASPMX.L.GOOGLE.COM (Priority 1) + backup MX records      | Routes incoming email to Google Workspace mailboxes                    | 3600 |
| A or CNAME (Web Forward) | @     | Forward to firstknock.online                             | Ensures prospects who visit the domain see your main website           | 3600 |

## DNS Configuration Step-by-Step Walkthrough

1. Purchase domain at Namecheap or Google Domains — confirm no blacklist history via MXToolbox before completing purchase
2. Set up Google Workspace account for the domain — use the \$6/user/month Business Starter plan; create 3 mailboxes (e.g., alex@, team@, hello@tryfirstknock.com)
3. Add SPF Record: Log into DNS management → Add TXT record → Host: @ → Value: v=spf1 include:\_spf.google.com ~all → TTL: 3600
4. Generate DKIM Key: Google Admin Console → Apps → Gmail → Authenticate Email → Generate 2048-bit key → Copy TXT record value
5. Add DKIM Record: DNS management → Add TXT record → Host: google.\_domainkey → Value: [paste 2048-bit key] → TTL: 3600
6. Add DMARC Record: DNS management → Add TXT record → Host: \_dmarc → Value: v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@tryfirstknock.com → TTL: 3600
7. Configure MX Records: Add Google's MX records (ASPMX.L.GOOGLE.COM priority 1, ALT1.ASPMX.L.GOOGLE.COM priority 5, etc.) to route email to Workspace
8. Set Up Custom Tracking Domain: In your sending tool (e.g., Instantly.ai), generate a custom tracking subdomain → Add CNAME record in DNS → Host: track → Value: [provided by tool]
9. Configure Domain Forwarding: Set up a 301 redirect from tryfirstknock.com to firstknock.online in your registrar's forwarding settings
10. Verify All Records: Use MXToolbox.com to verify SPF, DKIM, DMARC, and MX records are all resolving correctly — do not begin warm-up until all pass
11. Activate DKIM in Google Admin: Return to Admin Console → Authenticate Email → Click 'Start Authentication' → Confirm status shows 'Authenticating email'
12. Begin Warm-Up: Add the new mailboxes to your warm-up tool (Instantly.ai warm-up network) and start the 4–6 week warm-up protocol

Every new domain and mailbox must complete a structured warm-up before being used for cold outreach. Skipping or rushing this process is the single most common cause of deliverability failure for scaling startups. The warm-up period establishes a positive sending history with ISPs by gradually increasing volume while maintaining high engagement rates.

**Table 10 — Phase 2 Domain Warm-Up Protocol (6-Week Schedule)**

| Week   | Domains Active | Mailboxes Active | Warm-Up Emails/Mail box/Day | Cold Emails/Mail box/Day | Total Daily Volume | Key Actions                                                                                               |
|--------|----------------|------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Week 1 | 1              | 3                | 3–5                         | 0                        | 9–15               | DNS verification complete. Warm-up tool active. Zero cold outreach. Monitor for flags.                    |
| Week 2 | 1              | 3                | 8–12                        | 0                        | 24–36              | Continue warm-up only. Ensure positive reply signals from warm-up network. Check Postmaster Tools.        |
| Week 3 | 1–2            | 3–6              | 15–20                       | 5–8                      | 60–168             | Introduce cold outreach at 5–8 emails/mailbox/day. Highly targeted lists only. Monitor bounce rate daily. |

|        |     |       |       |       |           |                                                                                                  |
|--------|-----|-------|-------|-------|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Week 4 | 2–3 | 6–9   | 20–25 | 10–15 | 180–360   | Scale cold outreach. Add second domain to warm-up. Verify list hygiene before each batch.        |
| Week 5 | 3–4 | 9–12  | 25–30 | 20–25 | 405–660   | Full rotation across 3 domains. A/B test subject lines. Pause any mailbox with bounce rate > 1%. |
| Week 6 | 4–5 | 12–15 | 30–35 | 30–40 | 720–1,125 | Approach full Phase 2 capacity. All domains active. Monitor per-domain health weekly.            |

## Warm-Up Pause Triggers

- Bounce rate on any single mailbox exceeds 2% — pause that mailbox immediately, clean the list segment, resume at 50% of previous volume after 48 hours
- Spam complaint rate exceeds 0.1% — pause all sending from that domain, review content and targeting, do not resume for 72 hours minimum
- Google Postmaster Tools shows domain reputation drop from 'High' to 'Medium' — reduce sending volume by 50% and increase warm-up ratio for 1 week
- Any mailbox receives a Google account warning or suspension notice — do not attempt to reactivate; retire the mailbox and create a replacement on a different domain
- Inbox placement rate drops below 80% on seed tests — pause cold outreach, increase warm-up volume, and review content for spam triggers

## 3.4 Domain Rotation Strategy

Domain rotation is the operational practice of distributing your total daily sending volume across

multiple domains and mailboxes rather than concentrating it on a single account. This mimics natural human sending behavior, prevents any single domain from accumulating excessive sending history, and provides redundancy if one domain experiences deliverability issues.

### Round-Robin Rotation Setup

- Configure your sending tool (Instantly.ai or Smartlead) to distribute campaigns across all active mailboxes using round-robin assignment
- Set a hard cap of 30–40 cold emails per mailbox per day — never exceed this regardless of campaign urgency
- Distribute sending across different time windows: 8–10am, 11am–1pm, 2–4pm in the prospect's local time zone to mimic natural human sending patterns
- Ensure no single domain sends more than 100–120 total emails per day across all its mailboxes (3 mailboxes times 40 emails = 120 max)
- Use your sending tool's inbox rotation feature to automatically balance load — do not manually manage this at scale

### Per-Domain Health Monitoring

Table 11 — Per-Domain Health Monitoring Schedule

| Monitoring Task         | Frequency                | Tool                          | Action Threshold                                                            |
|-------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Blacklist status check  | Weekly                   | MXToolbox Blacklist Check     | Any listing = immediate pause and investigation                             |
| Domain reputation score | Weekly                   | Google Postmaster Tools       | Drop to 'Low' = pause sending, investigate content                          |
| Bounce rate per domain  | Daily (active campaigns) | Sending tool dashboard        | geq 2% = pause and clean list immediately                                   |
| Spam complaint rate     | Daily (active campaigns) | Google Postmaster Tools       | geq 0.1% = pause and review targeting                                       |
| Inbox placement rate    | Weekly                   | Manual seed test or GlockApps | < 80% = reduce volume, increase                                             |
| DMARC report review     | Weekly                   | DMARC reporting email inbox   | warm-up ratio<br>Any SPF/DKIM failures = investigate and fix authentication |

### When to Retire a Domain



- Domain appears on 3 or more major blacklists simultaneously — retire immediately, do not attempt remediation
- Google Postmaster Tools shows sustained 'Low' reputation for more than 2 consecutive weeks despite reduced volume
- Spam complaint rate exceeds 0.3% on two or more consecutive campaigns — the domain's reputation is likely unrecoverable
- Domain has been active for 12+ months of cold outreach — proactively rotate in a fresh domain as a precaution even if metrics look healthy
- Any legal or compliance notice received related to the domain — retire immediately and consult legal counsel

### 3.5 Email Infrastructure Providers Comparison

Table 12 — Email Infrastructure Providers Comparison for FirstKnock.online

| Provider         | Best Use Case                                                 | Monthly Pricing                        | Deliverability                                    | API Support               | Warm-Up Support                          | FirstKnock Recommendation                                                                  |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Google Workspace | Primary Phase 1 & 2 sending — best for cold outreach at scale | \$6/user/month (Business Starter)      | Excellent — highest trust with Gmail recipients   | Yes — Gmail API           | No native warm-up — use third-party tool | Primary choice for all Phase 1 and Phase 2 mailboxes                                       |
| Microsoft 365    | Secondary infrastructure — diversifies sender reputation      | \$6/user/month (Business Basic)        | Excellent — best for Outlook-heavy prospect lists | Yes — Microsoft Graph API | No native warm-up — use third-party tool | Use for 1–2 domains to diversify; especially effective for enterprise prospects on Outlook |
| Mailgun          | Transactional email API — product notifications, receipts     | Pay-as-you-go from \$0.80/1,000 emails | Good for transactional ; poor for cold outreach   | Excellent REST API        | No                                       | Not recommended for cold outreach — use only for FirstKnock product transactional emails   |

|          |                                                     |                                           |                                                       |                    |    |                                                                                             |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SendGrid | High-volume transactional and marketing email       | Free up to 100/day; \$19.95/month for 50K | Good for marketing; restricted for cold outreach      | Excellent REST API | No | Use for product emails and newsletters only — not suitable for cold outreach infrastructure |
| Postmark | Transactional email with exceptional deliverability | \$15/month for 10K emails                 | Excellent for transactional — strict anti-spam policy | Yes — REST API     | No | Best-in-class for product transactional email but explicitly prohibits cold outreach use    |

Infrastructure Split Recommendation: Host cold outreach domains on Google Workspace (primary) and Microsoft 365 (secondary, 1–2 domains). This diversifies your sender reputation and ensures your emails match the email system of your prospects — D2D and field sales managers are split roughly 60/40 between Gmail and Outlook environments.

### 3.6 Scaling Roadmap: 50 → 500+ Emails/Day

**Table 13 — FirstKnock.online Email Scaling Roadmap: Phase 1 Through Advanced Scale**

| Phase                 | Timeframe | Domains Active                | Mailboxes                    | Daily Volume    | Primary Tool | Key Actions                                                      | Success Metrics                        |
|-----------------------|-----------|-------------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Phase 1A — Foundation | Weeks 1–4 | 0 custom domains (Gmail only) | 1 (firstknockhelp@gmail.com) | 0–20 emails/day | Instantly.ai | SPF/DKIM setup, warm-up begins, zero cold outreach first 2 weeks | Zero spam complaints, bounce rate < 1% |

|                               |             |                  |                 |                        |                           |                                                                                    |                                                                              |
|-------------------------------|-------------|------------------|-----------------|------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Phase 1B<br>— Gmail Ramp      | Weeks 5–8   | 0 custom domains | 1 Gmail account | 20–50 emails/day       | Instantly.ai              | First cold campaigns , A/B test messaging , monitor Postmaster Tools               | Open rate > 30%, reply rate > 5%                                             |
| Phase 2A<br>— Domain Launch   | Weeks 9–12  | 2 custom domains | 4–6 mailboxes   | 50–150 emails/day      | Instantly.ai              | Purchase domains, DNS config, begin domain warm-up, parallel to Gmail sending      | All domains pass MXToolbox checks, inbox placement > 90%                     |
| Phase 2B<br>— Rotation Active | Weeks 13–16 | 3–4 domains      | 9–12 mailboxes  | 150–300 emails/day     | Instantly.ai + Smartlead  | Full inbox rotation, per-domain monitoring , retire Gmail                          | Consistent reply rate > 4%, bounce rate < 1% per domain                      |
| Phase 2C<br>— Full Scale      | Weeks 17–24 | 5–6 domains      | 13–17 mailboxes | 300–500 emails/day     | Smartlead or Instantly.ai | Optimize sequences , add Microsoft 365 domains, CRM integration                    | 500 emails/day sustained, spam complaints < 0.1%, pipeline growth measurable |
| Phase 3<br>— Advanced Scale   | Month 6+    | 8–12 domains     | 20–34 mailboxes | 500–1,000 + emails/day | Smartlead + private SMTP  | Private SMTP servers for highest volume, full CRM automation, dedicated IP warming | 1,000+ emails/day , < 0.05% spam complaints , 90%+ inbox placement           |

## 4.1 Daily Sending Volume Caps by Phase

Table 14 — Daily Sending Volume Caps by Infrastructure Phase

| Phase                          | Infrastructure                | Per Mailbox Daily Cap | Per Domain Daily Cap | Total Daily Cap   | Hard Stop Trigger                                            |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Phase 1 — Gmail                | firstknockhelp@gmail.com      | 50 emails/day         | 50 emails/day        | 50 emails/day     | Any bounce rate > 1% or spam complaint                       |
| Phase 2A — Early Custom Domain | 2 domains, 4–6 mailboxes      | 30–40 emails/mailbox  | 90–120 emails/domain | 150 emails/day    | Bounce rate > 2% on any mailbox                              |
| Phase 2B — Mid Scale           | 3–4 domains, 9–12 mailboxes   | 30–40 emails/mailbox  | 90–120 emails/domain | 300 emails/day    | Spam complaint rate > 0.1% on any domain                     |
| Phase 2C — Full Scale          | 5–6 domains, 13–17 mailboxes  | 30–40 emails/mailbox  | 90–120 emails/domain | 500 emails/day    | Any domain blacklisted or Postmaster reputation drops to Low |
| Phase 3 — Advanced             | 8–12 domains, 20–34 mailboxes | 30–40 emails/mailbox  | 90–120 emails/domain | 1,000+ emails/day | Sustained complaint rate > 0.05% across network              |

## 4.2 Email Content Best Practices

### Spam Trigger Words to Avoid

Spam filters use content scoring algorithms that assign risk points to specific words, phrases, and formatting patterns. The following categories of language should be avoided in cold outreach subject lines and body copy:

- Financial/Urgency Triggers: 'Free', 'Guaranteed', 'No risk', 'Act now', 'Limited time', 'Earn money', 'Make money fast', 'Cash', 'Profit', 'Double your income'
- Promotional Language: 'Buy now', 'Order now', 'Click here', 'Special offer', 'Exclusive deal', 'Discount', 'Save big', 'Best price', 'Lowest price'

- Credibility Undermining: 'As seen on', 'Award winning', 'Certified', 'Guaranteed results', 'No questions asked', 'Risk-free'
- Formatting Red Flags: ALL CAPS subject lines, excessive exclamation marks (!!!), multiple question marks (???), dollar signs (\$\$\$), emoji overuse in subject lines
- Deceptive Patterns: 'Re:' or 'Fwd:' in subject lines when there is no prior conversation, misleading preview text, hidden unsubscribe links

### Subject Line Best Practices

- Keep subject lines under 50 characters — they display fully on mobile without truncation
- Use the prospect's first name or company name for personalization: 'Quick question for [Company]' or '[First Name] — saw your team at [Event]'
- Ask a genuine question rather than making a claim: 'How does [Company] handle route planning?' outperforms 'We help companies like yours save 30%'
- Avoid clickbait — if the subject line does not match the email body, spam complaints will spike
- Test 2–3 subject line variants per campaign and rotate based on reply rate, not open rate
- For D2D/field sales audiences, reference their specific context: 'Field team efficiency at [Company]' or 'Door-to-door CRM for [Company]'

### Text-to-Link Ratio & Formatting Guidelines

Table 15 — Email Content Formatting Guidelines for Cold Outreach

| Element         | Recommendation                                           | Rationale                                                              |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Email Length    | Under 80 words for initial outreach                      | Brevity signals confidence; longer emails score higher on spam filters |
| Links per Email | Maximum 1 link                                           | Each additional link increases spam filter score significantly         |
| Images          | Zero images in cold outreach                             | Images trigger spam filters and are blocked by default in many clients |
| HTML Formatting | Plain text only for cold outreach                        | Plain text emails feel human; HTML emails feel promotional             |
| Font Styling    | No bold, italic, or colored text in cold outreach        | Formatting signals marketing email, not personal communication         |
| Signature       | Simple text signature — name, title, phone, website only | Avoid image-based signatures or multiple links in signature            |

|                  |                                                                                    |                                                                  |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Unsubscribe Link | Required if sending 5,000+/day across network; optional but recommended below that | Compliance with 2024/2025 Gmail and Yahoo bulk sender guidelines |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|

### 4.3 Engagement Optimization Tactics

#### Personalization at Scale for D2D/Field Sales Audiences

- Use dynamic fields for first name, company name, city/region, and industry vertical in every email — generic blasts to field sales managers will be ignored
- Reference a specific, observable detail about the prospect's business: team size, recent hiring activity, geographic expansion, or a LinkedIn post
- For D2D audiences specifically, reference the challenges unique to their world: route optimization, rep turnover, commission tracking, territory management — show you understand their day
- Use conditional content blocks in your sending tool to vary messaging based on company size: a 5-person D2D team needs different messaging than a 500-person field sales organization
- Limit personalization tokens to 2–3 per email — over-personalization feels automated and triggers suspicion

#### A/B Testing Framework

- Test one variable at a time: subject line OR opening line OR call-to-action — never multiple variables simultaneously
- Run each variant on a minimum of 50 sends before drawing conclusions — smaller sample sizes produce unreliable data
- Primary success metric for cold outreach: reply rate (not open rate, not click rate)
- Test cadence: run A/B tests for 5–7 business days before declaring a winner and updating your master template
- Document all test results in a shared tracking sheet — institutional knowledge about what works for D2D audiences is a competitive asset

#### Optimal Send Times for D2D/Field Sales Audiences

Table 16 — Optimal Send Times for D2D and Field Sales Audiences

| Time Window       | Day               | Expected Performance | Rationale                                                                                 |
|-------------------|-------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 7:30–9:00 AM      | Tuesday–Thursday  | Highest reply rates  | Field sales managers review email before hitting the road; decision-making window is open |
| 11:00 AM–12:00 PM | Tuesday–Wednesday | High reply rates     | Mid-morning break; managers are between calls or route check-ins                          |
| 4:00–5:30 PM      | Tuesday–Thursday  | Moderate reply rates | End-of-day wind-down; managers are back from field and reviewing communications           |
| Monday AM         | Monday            | Low — avoid          | Planning day; managers are in team meetings and setting weekly priorities                 |
| Friday PM         | Friday            | Very low — avoid     | Mental checkout; low engagement and high unsubscribe risk                                 |

## Follow-Up Sequence Best Practices

- Limit follow-up sequences to 3–4 total touchpoints — beyond 4 emails, reply rates drop below 1% and spam complaint risk increases
- Space follow-ups: Day 1 (initial), Day 4 (follow-up 1), Day 9 (follow-up 2), Day 16 (final breakup email)
- Each follow-up should add new value — a different angle, a relevant case study, a specific question — not just 'bumping this up'
- The 'breakup email' (final follow-up) consistently generates the highest reply rates of any sequence step — use it every time: 'Should I close your file?'
- Never send more than one email per day to the same prospect — this is the fastest path to a spam complaint

## 4.4 List Hygiene Schedule

**Table 17 — List Hygiene Schedule for FirstKnock.online**

| Task                               | Frequency                    | Tool                                  | Action                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Email verification of new leads    | Before every campaign launch | ZeroBounce, NeverBounce, or Hunter.io | Remove invalid, catch-all, and disposable addresses before sending                                         |
| Bounce list suppression            | After every campaign         | Sending tool + CRM                    | Add all hard bounces to global suppression list immediately                                                |
| Unsubscribe list sync              | Daily (automated)            | Sending tool → CRM sync               | Ensure unsubscribes are honored across all tools within 24 hours                                           |
| Engagement re-scoring              | Weekly                       | CRM / sending tool                    | Flag contacts with zero engagement after 3 touchpoints for removal or re-engagement sequence               |
| Full list audit                    | Monthly                      | ZeroBounce bulk verification          | Re-verify entire active contact list; remove any addresses that have gone stale                            |
| Suppression list review            | Monthly                      | CRM                                   | Confirm suppression list is synced across all sending tools and domains                                    |
| Re-engagement vs. removal decision | Quarterly                    | CRM segmentation                      | Contacts with zero engagement in 90 days: send one re-engagement email; if no response, remove permanently |
| Domain blacklist check             | Weekly                       | MXToolbox Blacklist Check             | Verify all sending domains are clean; investigate any new listings immediately                             |

## Email Verification Tools

- ZeroBounce: Industry-leading accuracy, real-time API, catch-all detection, spam trap identification — recommended primary tool
- NeverBounce: Strong bulk verification, good API, competitive pricing for high-volume lists — recommended secondary/backup tool



- Hunter.io: Best for finding and verifying email addresses during prospecting, not just bulk verification — use for lead sourcing
- Verification Threshold: Remove any address with a 'risky', 'catch-all', or 'invalid' status — only send to 'valid' addresses to keep bounce rates below 1%

## 4.5 Monitoring & Response Protocols

### Incident Response: Bounce Rate Exceeds 2%

1. Immediately pause all active campaigns on the affected domain or mailbox
2. Export the bounce list from your sending tool and add all hard bounces to your global suppression list
3. Run the remaining unsent list through ZeroBounce or NeverBounce — remove all non-valid addresses
4. Investigate the source of the bounced addresses: were they from a purchased list, a scraped source, or an unverified import?
5. Check MXToolbox to confirm the sending domain has not been blacklisted as a result of the bounce spike
6. Resume sending at 50% of previous volume after 48 hours — only after list has been cleaned and verified
7. Monitor bounce rate daily for the following 2 weeks — if it spikes again above 1%, retire the affected mailbox

### Incident Response: Spam Complaint Rate Exceeds 0.1%

1. Immediately pause all campaigns on the affected domain — do not send another email until root cause is identified
2. Review the content of the flagged campaign: subject line, body copy, links, and call-to-action for spam trigger patterns
3. Review the targeting: were these contacts properly opted-in or verified? Were they relevant to the FirstKnock value proposition?
4. Check Google Postmaster Tools for domain reputation status — if it has dropped, you have a 48–72 hour window to recover before permanent damage
5. Reduce sending volume by 75% when resuming — rebuild reputation slowly over 2–3 weeks
6. Increase warm-up email ratio relative to cold outreach for the affected domain for 2 weeks post-incident
7. If complaint rate exceeds 0.3% on any single campaign, consider retiring the domain and replacing it with a fresh one

### Google Postmaster Tools Setup

1. Navigate to [postmaster.google.com](https://postmaster.google.com) and sign in with your Google account
2. Click 'Add Domain' and enter each sending domain ([tryfirstknock.com](https://tryfirstknock.com), [getfirstknock.com](https://getfirstknock.com),

- etc.)
3. Verify domain ownership by adding the provided TXT record to your DNS
  4. Allow 24–48 hours for data to begin populating — Postmaster Tools requires a minimum sending volume to display metrics
  5. Monitor the following dashboards weekly: Domain Reputation, IP Reputation, Spam Rate, Delivery Errors, Encryption
  6. Set up a weekly calendar reminder to review Postmaster Tools every Monday morning before launching new campaigns
  7. Export and log reputation scores monthly to track trends over time — early degradation is much easier to reverse than advanced damage

Critical Reminder: Deliverability in 2025 is primarily a technical compliance problem, not a content problem. Without proper SPF, DKIM, and DMARC alignment on every sending domain, emails will be automatically rejected or delayed by Gmail and Yahoo regardless of how well-written they are. Authentication is non-negotiable.

## 5. Quick-Start Action Plan — 30-Day Checklist for FirstKnock.online

The following 30-day action plan translates this entire playbook into a prioritized, week-by-week execution schedule. Each task includes an owner designation, priority level, and the specific outcome it produces. Complete tasks in order — the sequence matters, as later tasks depend on earlier foundations.

### Week 1 — Foundation Setup (Days 1–7)

Table 18 — Week 1 Action Plan: Foundation Setup

| Day   | Task                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Owner               | Priority | Outcome                                             |
|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Day 1 | Sign up for Google Postmaster Tools at <a href="https://postmaster.google.com">postmaster.google.com</a> — add <a href="https://firstknock.online">firstknock.online</a> and verify domain ownership | Founder / Tech Lead | Critical | Domain reputation monitoring active from Day 1      |
| Day 1 | Audit <a href="mailto:firstknockhelp@gmail.com">firstknockhelp@gmail.com</a> — confirm it is not already flagged or limited by Google                                                                | Founder             | Critical | Confirm Phase 1 sending account is clean and usable |

|       |                                                                                                           |             |          |                                                                      |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 2 | Sign up for Instantly.ai (\$30–\$37/month) — connect firstknockhelp@gmail.com and enable warm-up          | Growth Lead | Critical | Automated warm-up begins building sender reputation                  |
| Day 2 | Configure SPF record for firstknock.online (if using Google Workspace):<br>v=spf1 include:_spf.googl      | Tech Lead   | Critical | Authentication foundation established for primary domain             |
| Day 3 | Generate and activate DKIM 2048-bit key via Google Admin Console for firstknock.online                    | Tech Lead   | Critical | Email signing active — prevents spoofing and improves deliverability |
| Day 3 | Add DMARC TXT record for firstknock.online:<br>v=DMARC1;<br>p=none;<br>rua=mailto:dmarc@firstknock.online | Tech Lead   | Critical | DMARC monitoring begins — collect authentication reports             |
| Day 4 | Verify all DNS records using MXToolbox.com — confirm SPF, DKIM, DMARC all pass                            | Tech Lead   | Critical | Authentication stack confirmed working before any sending            |
| Day 4 | Research and shortlist 5 lookalike domain names for Phase 2 (tryfirstknock.com, getfirstknock.com, etc.)  | Growth Lead | High     | Phase 2 domain strategy defined — ready to purchase in Week 4        |

|       |                                                                                                        |                       |        |                                                                  |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|--------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 5 | Build initial prospect list of 200–300 verified D2D/field sales contacts using ZeroBounce verification | Growth Lead           | High   | Clean, verified list ready for Week 2 warm-up and early outreach |
| Day 6 | Draft 3 cold email templates tailored to D2D/field sales pain points — plain text, under 80 words each | Founder / Growth Lead | High   | Campaign content ready for Week 2 launch                         |
| Day 7 | Set up custom tracking domain in Instantly.ai — configure CNAME record in DNS                          | Tech Lead             | Medium | Click tracking isolated from shared blacklisted domains          |

## Week 2 — Warm-Up Begins & First Campaigns (Days 8–14)

**Table 19 — Week 2 Action Plan: Warm-Up & First Campaigns**

| Day   | Task                                                                                             | Owner       | Priority | Outcome                                                           |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 8 | Confirm Instantly.ai warm-up is active and sending 3–5 emails/day — verify in dashboard          | Growth Lead | Critical | Warm-up protocol confirmed active and building reputation         |
| Day 8 | Send first 5–10 cold emails manually from firstknockhelp@gmail.com to highest-priority prospects | Founder     | High     | First real outreach sent — begin tracking reply rate              |
| Day 9 | Check Google Postmaster Tools for any early flags or reputation signals                          | Tech Lead   | High     | Early warning system active — catch problems before they escalate |

|        |                                                                                            |             |          |                                                                             |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 10 | Review bounce rate and spam complaints from first send batch in Instantly.ai dashboard     | Growth Lead | Critical | Confirm bounce rate < 1% and zero spam complaints before continuing         |
| Day 11 | A/B test 2 subject line variants on next 20-email batch — track reply rate per variant     | Growth Lead | Medium   | Begin building institutional knowledge on what resonates with D2D audiences |
| Day 12 | Add all bounced addresses to suppression list — run remaining list through ZeroBounce      | Growth Lead | High     | List hygiene maintained — bounce rate stays below threshold                 |
| Day 14 | Weekly review: open rate, reply rate, bounce rate, spam complaints — log in tracking sheet | Growth Lead | High     | Baseline metrics established for Week 3 optimization                        |

## Week 3 — Monitor, Optimize & Scale (Days 15–21)

**Table 20 — Week 3 Action Plan: Monitor, Optimize & Scale**

| Day    | Task                                                                                         | Owner       | Priority | Outcome                                                           |
|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 15 | Increase daily send volume to 20–25 emails/day if Week 2 metrics are all in green zone       | Growth Lead | High     | Controlled volume increase — only if all health metrics are clean |
| Day 15 | Review A/B test results from Week 2 — select winning subject line and update master template | Growth Lead | Medium   | Optimized template based on real data, not assumptions            |

|        |                                                                                          |                       |        |                                                                                |
|--------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 16 | Run MXToolbox blacklist check on firstknock.online — confirm clean status                | Tech Lead             | High   | Proactive blacklist monitoring — catch issues before they compound             |
| Day 17 | Draft follow-up sequence (3 emails total) for non-responders from Week 2 campaigns       | Founder / Growth Lead | High   | Automated follow-up sequence ready — maximizes response from existing outreach |
| Day 18 | Activate follow-up sequence in Instantly.ai for Week 2 non-responders                    | Growth Lead           | High   | Follow-up cadence running — Day 4, Day 9, Day 16 touchpoints                   |
| Day 19 | Review DMARC reports received at dmarc@firstknock.online — check for SPF/DKIM            | Tech Lead             | Medium | Authentication alignment confirmed — no spoofing or misconfiguration issues    |
| Day 21 | Weekly review: compare Week 3 metrics to Week 2 baseline — identify trends and anomalies | Growth Lead           | High   | Data-driven optimization — adjust targeting or content based on performance    |

## Week 4 — Phase 2 Preparation & DNS Groundwork (Days 22–30)

**Table 21 — Week 4 Action Plan: Phase 2 Preparation & DNS Groundwork**

| Day    | Task                                                                                         | Owner               | Priority | Outcome                                                  |
|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 22 | Purchase 2 priority lookalike domains (tryfirstknock.com + getfirstknock.com) from Namecheap | Founder / Tech Lead | Critical | Phase 2 domains secured — begin aging period immediately |

|        |                                                                                                  |             |          |                                                                               |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 22 | Run MXToolbox blacklist check on both new domains before completing purchase                     | Tech Lead   | Critical | Confirm purchased domains have no prior spam history                          |
| Day 23 | Set up Google Workspace accounts on both new domains (3 mailboxes each)                          | Tech Lead   | Critical | 6 new Phase 2 mailboxes created and ready for DNS configuration               |
| Day 24 | Configure complete DNS stack for tryfirstknock.com: SPF, DKIM, DMARC, MX, CNAME tracking         | Tech Lead   | Critical | First Phase 2 domain fully authenticated and ready for warm-up                |
| Day 25 | Configure complete DNS stack for getfirstknock.com: SPF, DKIM, DMARC, MX, CNAME tracking         | Tech Lead   | Critical | Second Phase 2 domain fully authenticated and ready for warm-up               |
| Day 26 | Verify all DNS records for both new domains using MXToolbox — confirm all pass                   | Tech Lead   | Critical | Phase 2 authentication stack confirmed before warm-up begins                  |
| Day 27 | Add all 6 new Phase 2 mailboxes to Instantly.ai warm-up network — begin 4–6                      | Growth Lead | Critical | Phase 2 warm-up begins — domains will be ready for cold outreach in 4–6 weeks |
| Day 28 | week warm-up<br>Increase Phase 1 Gmail sending to 30–35 emails/day (if all metrics remain green) | Growth Lead | High     | Continued Phase 1 scaling while Phase 2 infrastructure warms up in parallel   |

|        |                                                                                                  |                       |          |                                                                                 |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 29 | Document all DNS configurations, login credentials, and tool settings in a shared operations doc | Tech Lead             | High     | Institutional knowledge captured — team can manage infrastructure independently |
| Day 30 | Full 30-day review: compile all metrics, assess Phase 1 performance, confirm Phase 2 timeline    | Founder + Growth Lead | Critical | 30-day baseline established — data-driven decision on Phase 2 launch timing     |

### 30-Day Success Metrics

|                                                             |                                                            |                                                       |                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>200–350Phase 1 Target</b><br>Total Emails Sent (30 Days) | <b>&gt; 5%Cold Outreach Benchmark</b><br>Reply Rate Target | <b>&lt; 1%Must Stay Below</b><br>2%Bounce Rate Target | <b>6 mailboxesReady in 4–6 Weeks</b><br>Phase 2 Mailboxes Warming |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|

30-Day Milestone: By the end of Day 30, FirstKnock.online should have a fully authenticated Phase 1 sending account generating consistent replies, two Phase 2 domains with 6 mailboxes actively warming up, and a clear data-driven view of which messaging resonates with D2D and field sales audiences. This is the foundation everything else is built on.

### Appendix — Key Resources & Tools

Table 22 — Key Tools & Resources for FirstKnock.online Email Infrastructure

| Resource                | URL / Tool            | Purpose                                          |
|-------------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Google Postmaster Tools | postmaster.google.com | Domain reputation monitoring, spam rate tracking |
| MXToolbox               | mxtoolbox.com         | SPF/DKIM/DMARC verification, blacklist checking  |
| ZeroBounce              | zerobounce.net        | Email list verification and bounce prevention    |
| NeverBounce             | neverbounce.com       | Bulk email verification, real-time API           |
| Hunter.io               | hunter.io             | Email finding and verification for prospecting   |



|                  |                      |                                                   |
|------------------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Instantly.ai     | instantly.ai         | Cold email sending, warm-up, campaign management  |
| Smartlead        | smartlead.ai         | High-volume cold email sending and inbox rotation |
| GlockApps        | glockapps.com        | Inbox placement testing and spam filter analysis  |
| Namecheap        | namecheap.com        | Domain registration for lookalike domains         |
| Google Workspace | workspace.google.com | Email hosting for custom domains (\$6/user/month) |

*This playbook is a living document. Update it quarterly as Gmail and Yahoo deliverability guidelines evolve, as new sending tools emerge, and as FirstKnock.online's outreach volume scales. The principles — authenticate everything, warm up slowly, scale horizontally, monitor obsessively — remain constant regardless of the tools or volumes involved.*